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Becoming employable: how migrants navigate norms of employment, ethnicity, and gender within Swedish municipal labour market programmes

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ABSTRACT

This article investigates how migrant and refugee participants in Swedish municipal labour market programmes make sense of work and identity within the context of activation policies. While these programmes aim to promote integration and employability, they often reflect and reproduce normative ideals tied to ethnicity and gender. Drawing on qualitative interviews with participants from three municipalities, the study demonstrates how individuals navigate subject positions offered by the activation programmes and how these positions are shaped by ideals of the 'abstract worker' and normative practices of 'doing employment'. The findings reveal how municipal labour market programmes simultaneously enable and constrain participants: they open paths to employment and independence for some – particularly migrant women – but often reinforce ethnicized and gendered norms that limit participants' agency and opportunities. Participants' experiences show that employability is not a neutral concept, but one deeply embedded in cultural and institutional expectations around Swedishness, masculinity, and femininity. This study contributes to debates on the social justice implications of activation policies by highlighting how local labour market programmes both discipline and enable. The article argues that policies aimed at inclusion may, paradoxically, reproduce exclusion through the very norms they seek to enforce. Understanding how employment is shaped by culture and power relations is essential to design labour market interventions that foster real equity.

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Introduction

The integration of migrants and refugees into the labour market is frequently portrayed as a cornerstone of successful societal inclusion. In Sweden, as in many other countries, this goal has been pursued through activation policies and local labour market programmes (LLMPs) aimed at supporting individuals who face barriers to employment. These interventions serve a dual purpose: promoting economic self-sufficiency and fostering social inclusion, often through training, internships, and other preparatory activities (Nord 2018).

Regardless of these intentions, previous research highlights that refugees in Sweden face significant disadvantages in the labour market due to experiences of trauma, varying educational and professional backgrounds, language barriers, and systemic racism (Larsson 2015; Vernby and Dancygier 2019). As a result, a range of targeted activation policies have emerged to accelerate

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refugees' entry into the workforce (Parsland 2024). The activation programmes in our study are intertwined with integration policy, as participants with a refugee background and limited Swedish language proficiency are placed in a separate group from other participants, with activation interventions specifically targeting this group. However, despite activation policies being a key feature of contemporary welfare states and integration, the lived experiences of those participating in municipal labour market programmes remain underexplored.

Activation policies promote labour market participation through obligations to engage in work-related activities. Rooted in a neoliberal logic of individual responsibility, employability, and self-sufficiency, they construct paid employment as the dominant marker of social value (Nord 2018; Östling, Nyhlén, and Giritli Nygren 2025). LLMPs operationalize these policy ideals at the local level, framing wage labour as both a means of livelihood and a condition for social belonging. Further, while LLMPs are often framed as neutral instruments to promote labour market participation, they also operate as sites where subjects are shaped through normative assumptions about work, ethnicity, and gender, as well as their intersections (Acker 2012; Parsland 2025). This can be exemplified by previous research that has shown that migrants and refugees, positioned as 'others' in relation to the ideal of the self-sufficient worker (Forslund et al. 2019; Vesterberg 2016), are subject to more rigid and ethnically marked activation measures than other (often white) unemployed individuals (Parsland 2024). This creates a complex terrain for migrants and refugees, who must navigate both structural barriers and preconceptions, while also negotiating their subject position within a framework that often essentializes their identities based on ethnicity and/or gender (Jenson 2015; Parsland and Ulmestig 2022; Vesterberg 2016). Addressing the lack of research on participants' experiences, this study examines how migrant participants experience activation and navigate these structures as recipients of such discourses.

Against this background, this paper aims to explore how refugee participants negotiate their subject positions within the broader norms of employment, ethnicity, and gender that underpin these LLMPs. To do so, we draw on Mulhall's (2013) concept of *doing employment* which illustrates how enhancing employability is enacted through the practices of activation programmes, and Acker's (2012) concept of the *abstract worker* referring to an idealized figure presumed to be universally adaptable to wage work conditions, unencumbered by race or gender. Nevertheless, in reality, this figure is deeply embedded in norms that marginalize those who deviate from it (Acker 2012.). Drawing on qualitative interviews, this article seeks to contribute to a deeper understanding of how migrants and refugees make sense of work and identity within the context of LLMPs. In this article, we argue that the LLMP assigns participants with migrant backgrounds subject positions shaped by gender and ethnicity, which both restrict and enable the opportunities they experience in working life. The participants renegotiate their identity and the meaning of work by adapting to or resisting given structures and norms. By centring participants' experiences, the article offers new insight into the everyday consequences of activation policy for socially disadvantaged groups and also contributes to broader debates about the implications of activation policies for equity and social justice.

Previous research: activation and the politics of categorization

Previous studies on participants' experiences of active labour market policies have mainly examined their effects on participants' well-being and emotional responses (Govender 2023; Hultqvist and Hollertz 2023; Rose 2019). Critical research on activation policies and their entwinement with ethnicity and categorizations has primarily focused on policy documents and institutional frameworks (Östling, Nyhlén, and Giritli Nygren 2025; Söderqvist Forkby 2022; Vesterberg 2016), while fewer studies examine how ethnicized and gendered logics are experienced at the local level (Nada 2023; Parsland 2024). This leaves a gap in understanding how participants navigate these dynamics.

Activation policies can contain both empowering and disciplining elements (Johansson, Sarstrand Marekovic, and Forkby Söderqvist 2023), and often operate through differentiated

treatment of 'foreign-born' participants. On the one hand, Söderqvist Forkby (2022) argues that the differentiation of foreign-born participants in labour market interventions can be understood as a form of resource allocation to otherwise disadvantaged groups. However, on the other hand, Parsland (2024) shows how refugees are offered less flexibility, lower income, and more standardized interventions than native-born jobseekers, resulting in unequal access to resources and opportunities.

In line with Parsland's (2024) argument, other scholars have shown that migrants and refugees are often framed as culturally lacking and in need of stricter control than the general (often white) unemployed (Dahlstedt and Neergaard 2019; Vesterberg 2013, 2015). Such constructions frequently rely on stereotypical and racialized imaginaries in which migrants – especially refugees – are framed as passive, culturally deficient, and unemployable subjects who must be transformed into 'worthy' recipients of welfare through activation. For instance, Somali participants in a Swedish programme were portrayed as passive and gender-unequal, reinforcing a boundary between 'Swedishness' and 'otherness' (Vesterberg 2013). Other studies highlight similar ethnicized governance practices (Larsson 2015; Söderqvist Forkby 2022), where cultural assimilation and becoming more 'Swedish' are implicitly expected.

While much research has highlighted the ethnicized nature of activation policies, these processes rarely operate in isolation. They are deeply entangled with gendered assumptions about work and family (Haikkola 2021; Jenson 2015; Nada 2023; Parsland and Ulmestig 2022). Within activation programmes, ideas of cultural differences intersect with expectations around gender, thus reinforcing traditional gender roles. For example, one study by Parsland and Ulmestig (2022) showed that female participants in Sweden were overrepresented in subsidized employment within childcare, disability care, eldercare, and kitchen environments, while male participants were overrepresented in subsidized jobs in janitorial work, green area maintenance, and carpentry. Further, while ethnicity and gender are often treated separately in previous studies, studies that explore their intersection show how migrant women are seen as particularly distant from the labour market (Parsland and Ulmestig 2022) and represented as lazy and unwilling to work and thus in need of more repressive interventions (Mulinari 2018).

Whilst much of the previous literature focuses on institutional actors and policy design, fewer studies examine participants' own experiences and agency. Some exceptions, however, have explored how migrant women resist dominant norms by reimagining their futures (Östling 2025). Nada (2023) shows how migrant women resist traditional family roles, with active labour market programmes (ALMPs) enabling them to negotiate new positions within their families through labour market participation. In her study of labour market activation policies in Switzerland, she found that native-born women were reluctant to take on gendered, low-paid care work. In contrast, migrant women accepted such jobs with little resistance, as they were already challenging traditional gender norms simply by working outside the home. For them, the gendered, low-status, or poorly paid nature of the work was of secondary importance. These insights reveal how activation policies not only regulate access to work but shape identities and life trajectories as well.

Overall, previous studies reveal that activation policies are deeply embedded in ethnicized and gendered structures that shape both the LLMPs and opportunities for participation. However, research has seldom examined how these structures are experienced, resisted, and/or reinterpreted by participants themselves. This article addresses this gap by exploring how refugee participants negotiate their subject positions within the normative and intersecting frameworks that underpin local labour market programmes.

Theoretical framework: doing employment and the abstract worker

The theoretical framework used in this paper draws on a combination of Mulhall's (2013) concept of *doing employment* that captures how individuals actively perform and embody the

norms, values, and behaviours associated with being employable, and Acker (2012, 2006) concept the of the *abstract worker*. This concept represents the seemingly universal worker but is, in reality, a deeply gendered and classed ideal of the worker; a disembodied, fully available individual, unencumbered by care responsibilities or structural constraints. Although this figure appears neutral, it is historically modelled on the male breadwinner and therefore privileges those who can embody autonomy, availability, and uninterrupted commitment to paid labour (Acker 2012, 218). In the context of labour market and activation programmes, this ideal also becomes ethnically coded, as expectations of employability intersect with cultural norms and moral judgements about who is perceived as 'fit' for work or as a 'deserving' citizen (Nord 2018; Parsland 2025). Together, these perspectives illuminate both the structural and the performative dimensions of employability, that is, the normative ideals that define what it means to be a 'worker' (Acker 2012), and the everyday practices through which individuals enact, embody, or resist those ideals (Mulhall 2013).

Drawing on a Foucauldian understanding of discourse as something that 'governs the way that topics can be meaningfully talked about and reasoned about, and influences how ideas are put into practice and used to regulate the conduct of others' (Mulhall 2013, 181), Mulhall conceptualizes doing employment as a way to capture how individuals actively perform and embody the norms, values, and behaviours associated with employability. Within this framework, unemployment – much like madness in Foucault's analysis – becomes an object of knowledge and intervention, defined through institutional practices that seek to diagnose, manage, and 'cure' it (182). Active labour market policies and programmes are thus not merely instruments for economic integration, but mechanisms for producing employable subjects. Employability is therefore not understood as a fixed personal attribute, but as a situated and performative practice, in other words, something that is done through speech, conduct, and self-presentation in interactions with institutional actors. Within an activation context, doing employment thus entails learning to perform as a responsible, motivated, and work-oriented subject. However, Mulhall (2013) does not just simply show how participants in active labour market programmes reproduce these norms (cf. Parsland 2024; Parsland and Ulmestig 2022), rather she demonstrates that participants interpret, negotiate, and sometimes subtly resist them. How employment is done is therefore not a fixed process, but one open for resistance and change (see also Nada 2023).

While doing employment offers a way to examine how employability is performed, Acker's (2012) concept of the abstract worker helps situate these practices within the broader, gendered and ethnically coded norms that define the employable subject and the institutional practices of LLMPs. Hence, the abstract worker should not be understood as a fixed or static ideal, but as a historically and institutionally produced construct that is continuously (re)produced through gendered and racialized organizational practices, policy discourses, and everyday interactions. In other words, the abstract worker is not merely a normative backdrop against which employability is assessed, but a discursive figure that is actively made and sustained through labour market policies and activation programmes. Gender and ethnicity are therefore not external attributes that individuals bring into organizations, but constitutive dimensions through which the abstract worker is produced, normalized, and rendered intelligible. Identities are thus constituted within collective and institutional arrangements that are themselves gendered and racialized (Acker 2006; also; Acker 1990). Central to the forthcoming analysis is the recognition that labour market programmes operate within broader societal and institutional contexts where normative assumptions about work, ethnicity, and gender intersect and shape who can approximate the ideal of the abstract worker (Acker 2012; Parsland 2025).

Against that background, we understand the doing employment and the abstract worker as co-constituted, meaning that the practices of doing employment and becoming employable take shape in relation to the idealized abstract worker. Thereby, by combining these perspectives, we can engage with how refugee participants are doing employment, and how it unfolds in relation to, and sometimes in resistance to, the ideal abstract worker, thus revealing how subject positions are

negotiated within the normative and intersecting frameworks that underpin local labour market programmes.

Method and materials

The method used is a qualitative approach in the form of an interview study. In the spring of 2024, we conducted semi-structured interviews with participants from migrant and refugee backgrounds in municipal labour market programmes in three different municipalities in and around a major city region in Sweden. The programmes in which participants were enrolled combined Swedish for Immigrants (SFI) with work training placements at municipal labour market arenas, and in some cases short vocational courses, for example in cleaning and facility maintenance. These programmes were part of local activation initiatives aimed at strengthening participants' employability and integration into the Swedish society.

We conducted four focus group interviews and five individual interviews with a total of 16 participants: ten women and six men. Of them, six women and five men participated in the focus group interviews, while four women and one man took part in the individual interviews. The focus groups consisted of between two and four participants per session. In the focus groups, we interviewed men and women separately. Our initial ambition was to conduct focus group interviews only, as this format enables interaction between participants and allows shared experiences of activation to be discussed and negotiated collectively (Wilkinson 1998). However, some participants expressed a preference for individual interviews, which we accommodated to facilitate participation and ensure that individuals who might not feel comfortable speaking in a group setting could still contribute.

A drawback of focus groups is that some individuals may dominate the conversation. We addressed this by directing questions to all participants to ensure everyone had the opportunity to speak. Two interviewers conducted the sessions using an interview guide, applying a flexible approach. The questions focused mainly on participants' experiences of labour market programme activities, their hopes and dreams for the future, and what work means to them. The interviews lasted between 19 and 49 min.

Due to language barriers, the interviews were conducted with the help of a professional interpreter who translated both the questions and the participants' responses, as they spoke in their mother tongue. We are aware that the use of interpreters may introduce additional layers of mediation and potentially affect nuance, phrasing, and the immediacy of interaction (cf. Wallin and Ahlström 2006). To mitigate such effects, we asked clarifying questions to both the interpreter and the participant when needed, and in some instances, the interpreter on their own initiative elaborated on expressions, nuances, or idiomatic language to make them meaningful in Swedish. While interpretation inevitably shapes the research encounter, excluding participants with limited Swedish proficiency would have risked reproducing the very forms of marginalization that this study seeks to examine. We therefore approached the use of interpreters not merely as a practical solution, but as an ethical and methodological choice aimed at ensuring that participants could express themselves in ways that felt meaningful, and that their experiences could be included in the analysis.

The participants originated from countries such as Afghanistan, Syria, and Ethiopia, coming to Sweden as refugees. A refugee is, by definition, also a migrant – that is, a person who has moved from one country to another. A refugee is a migrant who has fled their country because of danger or persecution. The interviewees have lived in Sweden for between 4 and 12 years, all of them arriving as adults. Most have little or no work experience in Sweden, although some – particularly the male participants – had work experience from their countries of origin. Most of the female participants in this study lacked both wage work experience and formal education from their home countries, with many being illiterate. The interview participants are middle-aged or older, and many have families and children living in Sweden.

It should be noted that the interviewees do not represent all individuals with a migrant or refugee background participating in active labour market interventions, as it is a very heterogenous group. However, rather than capturing the full heterogeneity of this population, the empirical material allows us to explore how migrants and refugees make sense of work and identity within this particular type of activation setting.

This study is part of a research programme funded by Forte and has received ethical approval from the Swedish Ethical Review Authority (registration number 2022–02320-01). All participants were informed about the study in advance and signed a written consent form. The interview material has been treated with strict confidentiality.

The interviews were analysed using thematic analysis inspired by Braun and Clarke (2006). The analysis began with familiarizing ourselves with the material by reading and rereading the interviews several times, underlining sections and words that appeared relevant to the research question, and making initial notes. During the coding process, we moved back and forth between theory and empirical material. The challenges of entering the labour market, as described by the participants, were analysed through the lens of prevailing work norms and the notion of the abstract worker that they reflect. The practices within the LLMP were analysed in terms of how the concept of doing employment was enacted in the programme. In the analysis ethnicity and Swedishness emerged as central aspects of the abstract worker and how employment is done by the participants. Furthermore, a comparative analysis was conducted between male and female participants' responses in order to capture a gendered dimension. Once we felt sufficiently familiar with the material and confident that the codes adequately represented the material, we proceeded to organize the codes into broader themes. This process resulted in the identification of three main themes: (1) Ethnic barriers to Employment: Exclusion through the Abstract Worker as Swedish, (2) Constructing Employability: How Gender and Ethnicity Shape Subject Positions, and (3) Gendered meanings of work: Negotiating Identities.

Analysis

As mentioned above, this section is structured according to the three main themes that emerged through our analysis. We begin by examining the ethnic barriers to employment and the ways in which labour market norms exclude migrants. We then turn to the practices within LLMPs, analysing how employability is actively constructed through participation. We investigate how participants themselves negotiate and respond to the subject positions these programmes produce. Finally, we consider the gendered meanings of work, illustrating how male and female participants attach different identities and values to employment.

Ethnic barriers to employment: exclusion through the abstract worker as Swedish

When talking to the participants, they all emphasized the importance of learning Swedish to get a job, and several of them described language as 'a key to everything'. All participants were either currently enrolled in or had previously attended, *Swedish for Immigrants* (SFI), yet many felt that SFI alone was insufficient or not the most effective way for them to learn the language. However, there was no doubt about the interviewees strong and explicit desire to learn and improve their Swedish, not only to increase their chances of finding work but also to participate more fully in social life and society.

The connection between language and employment opportunities was a recurring theme in all interviews. This link was also reinforced by the LLMP itself, which prioritized language acquisition when the participants entered the LLMP and further by consistently reminding them about the importance of language. Thereto, several participants had experienced the importance of language

first-hand by being turned down for jobs because their Swedish was considered inadequate, as reflected in the quote below by a participant that wanted to work as a painter, just as he did when living in Syria:

> For me personally, the only limitation I really have is the language. Other than that, there is nothing else I am lacking when it comes to work ability. It's just the language. . . . I have honestly tried hard, but everything depends on the language. They [the employers] said you have to know Swedish. Unfortunately, I've been rejected because of it. (Informant 1, man)

This quote illustrates how language and employability become intertwined, with language emerging not merely as a practical skill, but as a key marker of the ideal worker (Acker 2012) in the Swedish context. Language, in this context, is thus positioned not as a competence to be further developed through employment, but as a precondition for other forms of competence to be recognized as valid. In the excerpt above, the participant states that he has the physical capacity to perform the work tasks in question, but that his work ability is rendered insufficient due to limited proficiency in Swedish. Linguistic competence thus operates as a prior condition for employability, shaping which forms of knowledge and experience are acknowledged as legitimate within the labour market. Although labour market actors often emphasize that Swedish can be learned 'on the job', the participants' experiences suggest that Swedish proficiency is treated as a condition for accessing work rather than something that can be acquired through it. As a result, professional competence and physical work capacity become secondary to linguistic fluency.

From this perspective, the quote above could be seen as illustrating how the abstract ideal worker is implicitly imagined as ethnically Swedish, with Swedish as their mother tongue or spoken fluently rather than a skill acquired over time.

Nevertheless, the participants fully recognized the importance of being able to speak and understand Swedish. However, this also generate a frustration among them, particularly among the men who often had extensive work experience from their countries of origin. The strong emphasis within the LLMP on learning Swedish, primarily through SFI combined with entry-level work placements, meant that participants' existing competences and work experiences were overlooked. This institutional framing led many to feel that their prior knowledge and experiences were being devalued, as shown in this quote:

> I still think that Sweden should, in some way, have made use of the skills we have, the jobs and experience we bring from our home countries. They should have taken advantage of that for the country's development as well. (Informant 4, man)

The participants, especially the men, we interviewed often had many years of professional experience. One had worked as a painter for 20 years before starting his own bakery, which he ran for 9-years prior to coming to Sweden. Another had owned a business exporting oil from Syria to Lebanon, Turkey, and Jordan. Since entering the LLMP, he had been driving buses and working in gardening and agriculture while simultaneously attending SFI. He described these changes as a major shift from his previous life and explained that his current situation felt difficult:

> It's really hard, actually. Sometimes you feel ashamed to be in this situation. Because, you know . . . this feeling that you really want to contribute, and then to live on social welfare . . . it's very hard to accept that. (Informant 1, man)

This further shows how employability in the Swedish context and within the LLMP is structured around a culturally specific ideal of the worker; one that apart from language, values education and work experience that aligns with Swedish labour market expectations over prior experiences (Mulinari 2018). While (some) participants' prior work experience was extensive, the LLMP did not systematically build upon or actively match these competences with relevant job placements or work training. Instead, participants were typically directed towards SFI combined with standardized (and often temporary) job training activities within cultivation projects, agricultural work, or bus driving, regardless of their prior professional background. Consequently, participants were

required to repeatedly demonstrate basic employability without accumulating recognized professional capital that could place them on a trajectory towards stable employment corresponding to their competence. Hence, rather than shortening their distance to the labour market, the LLMP's organizational logic risks institutionalizing a standardized pathway that disregards prior qualifications and experiences gained abroad. In line with previous research (e.g. Larsson 2015; Vernby and Dancygier 2019), this reflects how structural inequalities and ethnic hierarchies in the labour market are reinforced by activation policies and through the LLMP (Dahlstedt and Neergaard 2019; Östling 2025; Parsland 2025).

At the same time, the quotes above also reveal subtle forms of resistance by the participants questioning the narrow institutional definitions of what counts as 'proper' work experience and competence. By emphasizing their prior professional experience and willingness to contribute, they challenged the implicit assumption that employability must be earned through conformity to Swedish norms of education, certification, and language. These accounts can therefore be seen as attempts to navigate and partially challenge the employable subject and how employment is done (Acker 2012; Mulhall 2013, also; Nada 2023).

However, this form of resistance was not equally available to the women in the study, several of whom lacked formal education and were illiterate and unable to read or write even in their first language, making participation in SFI-training particularly challenging:

> I do not remember everything that was said there. When you are illiterate, you cannot take notes and then go back and read what was discussed. And during the time I was in school – which was a year and a half – considering that I cannot read or write in Persian, it became very overwhelming for me in the classroom. It affected my mental well-being and gave me headaches. (Informant 8, woman)

Many of the women had previously been homemakers and therefore lacked formal work experience. In contrast to the men, the women generally felt that their participation within the LLMP corresponded well with their earlier experiences, as most were assigned to kitchens, cleaning, or, in some cases, child- and eldercare. However, these positions often involved physically demanding tasks, and several women described health problems that made the work difficult to sustain. Still, they expressed a strong willingness to work, though they wished that the tasks could be better adapted to their physical capacities, as illustrated in the quote below:

> I want to be able to work and go to school [to learn Swedish], but going to school doesn't work for me [. . .] I feel stressed and unwell and get headaches. I want to work, but I have problems with my hands, legs, and feet. I want a job that isn't too heavy because of my difficulties. (Informant 8, woman)

These accounts highlight how women's opportunities to do employment were shaped and constrained by intersecting structures of gender, ethnicity and able-bodiedness, showing how the institutional framework of the LLMP assumes a subject capable of continuous participation, linguistic competence, and physical ability. Within this context, doing employment for female participants became less about enacting employability and more about coping with the dissonance between institutional expectations and their own realities; efforts involving both compliance with and resistance to the normative expectations embedded in the idea of the abstract worker. Thereby further exposing how the gendered and embodied boundaries of the employable subject are reproduced through LLMPs (also Parsland and Ulmestig 2022).

Constructing employability: how LLMP practices reproduce gendered and ethnicized subject positions

The previous section illustrated how ethnic hierarchies and institutional norms outside and within LLMPs exclude participants from being recognized as employable subjects. Central to this process is the way 'Swedishness' is constructed and taught within LLMP practices. Language training and work placements do not simply equip participants with practical skills; they

function as pedagogical and disciplinary sites where norms of communication, behaviour, and morality associated with being 'Swedish' are transmitted and embodied. In other words, through these activities, participants learn to perform employability in ways that align with a culturally specific and ethnically coded model of the (Swedish) worker. This echoes previous research showing how migrants are taught to become 'more Swedish' to be considered employable (Larsson 2015; Vesterberg 2016), revealing how LLMP practices position Swedishness as a normative ideal at the core of employability and as a form of ethnicized activation (Parsland 2024).

However, as shown above, LLMP activities tend to also reproduce traditional gender roles. Tasks assigned through activities, internships, and courses are gendered; women are often placed in roles coded as feminine, such as care work, cleaning, and kitchen duties. While in contrast, men are more commonly assigned to forest and park maintenance. For example, one of the female participants described a course named 'She can' [*Hon kan*], specifically designed for migrant women:

> In the course, we learned a lot about how we should behave, for example, when working in a restaurant. How to interact with other staff, how to use different cleaning products if you are to clean. Stuff like that. (Informant 12, woman)

Despite this just being one course, it serves as an example of the gendered nature of activation and the subject position offered to the participants, thus mirroring what Acker (2012) describes as a gendered division of labour. This type of course also reflects an underlying assumption that migrant women lack relevant experiences, and, as Mulinari (2018, 41) notes, come from 'cultures where women do not work' and therefore needs to learn how to participate in the labour market once in Sweden. From this perspective, courses such as *She Can* can be understood as feminist-inspired initiatives aimed at liberating women from traditional gender roles that confine them to the home, transforming them into independent, wage-earning, and gender-equal women.

Paradoxically, however, these courses reinforce some of the very gendered and racialized divisions they seek to challenge. By assigning certain career paths as appropriate for the 'female migrant', they reproduce normative ideas about which kinds of work different groups are suited for (see also Haikkola 2021; Jenson 2015; Parsland and Ulmestig 2022). This aligns with Mulinari's (2018) and Nada's (2023) observations that activation programmes often construct migrant women as a service class for others, expected to be compliant, caring, and willing to accept low-status jobs under poorer conditions. Hence, through these practices gendered and ethnicized subject positions are both produced and stabilized within the LLMP, constraining refugee women's opportunities for social mobility and shaping their aspirations towards what are considered 'realistic' futures.

This dynamic became particularly visible in the interviews with female participants, many of whom expressed that they did not dare to hope for more than "any job" that would allow them to earn a salary and become more independent. Throughout the interviews, having a job in itself was often described as a form of success, regardless of the type of work or its status. As illustrated in the following exchange with one of the male participants:

Interviewer: If you could dream freely, what would you like to do when you not enrolled with the LLMP anymore?

Informant 1, man: What I really want, once I've learned the language, is simply to get a job.

Interviewer: Could that be any kind of job?

Informant 1, man: Yes, preferably something that suits my language level and my age. [. . .] Having a job makes you feel that you exist. That we can feel we are doing something for this country, that we are part of this society. To get off welfare and social assistance and enter the labour market. That's what I want. Because we know that social assistance comes from taxpayers' money. Just like you work and pay taxes, we want to do that too. Then you don't feel excluded. We want to be part of this society and contribute in some way. You want to earn your money through your own sweat.

This quote further demonstrates how employability, in the context of the LLMP, becomes closely tied to moral worth and belonging. Other interviewees highlighted how a job is a way 'of getting out and about, and meeting new people' (Informant 8, woman), that it 'gives you energy, and make you feel good' (Informant 7, woman) and that 'it allows me to be useful to others, and at the same time, I don't have to sit at home with my own thoughts' (Informant 5, man).

To work is therefore not only to earn a living, but to become a recognizable subject – a legitimate, contributing member of society. Yet, this aspiration is framed within narrow boundaries, and to desire 'any job' becomes both a pragmatic adaptation to institutional expectations and a reflection of constrained possibilities. In this way, LLMP practices shape not only participants' present actions but also their imagined futures, disciplining what it is possible to hope for (cf. Östling, Nyhlén, and Giritli Nygren 2025).

From the perspective of doing employment (Mulhall 2013), these accounts illustrate how participants internalize and reproduce the moral and behavioural codes that define the employable subject. The participant's modest aspirations can be understood as a learned response to the institutional logic of activation, where employability is tied to responsibility, productivity, and self-sufficiency. Within this framework, doing employment means not only to participate in work-related activities but also to demonstrate the right attitude through gratitude, motivation, and willingness to accept any available job. This also shows how employability and the figuration of the 'good migrant' as someone who works hard, asks for little, and adapts to the system are intertwined. In this sense, LLMPs do not merely prepare participants for the labour market; they also regulate what forms of hope and ambition are considered legitimate and achievable. In other words, the dream of 'any job' becomes both a marker of inclusion and a symptom of constraint.

Gendered meanings of work: negotiating identities

For the migrant participants, a renegotiation of identity takes place – one shaped by gendered meanings of work. Male participants often describe a sense of loss of a position of respect and professional pride held in their countries of origin, as they now found themselves in marginalized and lower-status roles. Re-entering the labour market is therefore not only about securing income but about restoring independence, dignity, and a sense of social worth. This can be understood as a reconfiguration of the meaning of work: from being a core element of identity (linked to their occupation) to becoming a moral marker of legitimacy and belonging within Swedish society. Participation in the LLMP thus represents an opportunity to re-establish a form of masculinity through employment, albeit in more constrained and subordinated ways than before. These findings echo Hansen's (2017, 193) study in Norway, which showed that male participants, both native-born and migrants viewed 'paid employment as a requirement for recognition as a valuable citizen', thus making participation in different activation programmes in to a 'breadwinner project' to regain social value and status. This suggests that employability is not only an economic or institutional category but a gendered framework through which masculine identity is reconstructed under new social and cultural conditions.

In contrast, the female participants less frequently described paid employment as a source of existential value or personal validation. Before coming to Sweden, their identities were primarily structured around family roles (as mothers, caretakers, and homemakers) rather than through wage

labour. Their narratives highlight how norms surrounding employment are gendered differently across cultural contexts. Several women described how, after arriving in Sweden, they became increasingly aware of new expectations that women, like men, should work and be financially independent.

Against that background, some participants spoke about navigating between competing ideals of womanhood, where employment was simultaneously seen as a pathway to independence and as a potential challenge to traditional family roles. While some experienced balancing the demands of family responsibilities with those of the LLMP as a source of tension, many also viewed the LLMP as a space for transformation. From this perspective, participation became a way to renegotiate and reconstruct a sense of self as an independent and capable woman. As one participant explained:

> [W]hat I do know is that when you work . . . And you become responsible for yourself. You're no longer under someone else's control. Like your husband or someone else . . . My wish is to live in a place that is calm and safe, where I can feel completely free. When I lived in Syria, if I wanted to visit a female neighbor, I had to get permission or approval from my husband. In Syria, I didn't have big dreams, and I didn't have the possibility to make any decisions. But here, I feel like I have a lot of space, and I'm not even ready yet to think about everything I could . . . to dream more, yes. (Informant 6, woman)

For this participant, and others like her, employment symbolizes a rejection of the dependent housewife role and the embrace of autonomy.

Further, this informant also notes that her husband opposes her participation in a work placement and emphasizes that she therefore values the LLMP's support in asserting that she is obliged to take part in such a placement. Hence, as Johansson, Sarstrand Marekovic, and Forkby Söderqvist (2023) argue, activation programmes operate through a dual logic of discipline and empowerment, producing compliant subjects while simultaneously enabling possibilities for resistance and self-definition (cf. Mulhall 2013). Within this ambivalent framework, women's entry into paid work, even when shaped by coercive or conditional activation measures, can disrupt patriarchal power structures, as well as the division between men's productive and women's reproductive labour (Acker 2012). Participation in LLMPs thus becomes more than an institutional obligation. It represents a potential pathway towards emancipation from patriarchal norms and the reimagining of self-directed, autonomous identities.

However, not all women in the study fully embraced the subject position of the employable worker. Some identified more strongly with motherhood and caregiving, expressing a desire to remain (more) at home to focus on their families. For example, one woman explained that, if given the choice, she would prioritize caring for her children over paid work:

> I would choose to be at home with my children. [. . .] As things are now, it works fine, because the time I spend here, the children are at school, and I still have time to come home, cook, and prepare what they need. So, it works, it's good. I'm here until twelve, then the children really need me. (Informant 7, woman)

Her account illustrates how women seek to reconcile competing expectations of being a good mother and a productive worker. This tension reflects the underlying logic of the abstract worker as an individual continuously available for paid labour, and unencumbered by care responsibilities, bodily limitations, or competing social roles. However, as Acker (2012) notes, this figuration presupposes a separation between productive and reproductive labour, making it inherently gendered. The participant quoted above thus exposes the gap between the gender-neutral abstraction of employability and the embodied experience of women whose time and energy are divided between paid and unpaid forms of work. Her negotiation of work on her own terms can thus be seen as a critique of the abstract worker ideal, revealing how gendered and embodied conditions complicate the very notion of employability.

Discussion

The aim of this article has been to investigate how migrants and refugees participating in municipal labour market programmes make sense of work and identity, and how they negotiate their subject positions in relation to norms of employment, ethnicity, and gender. Our analysis has shown how language becomes a central marker of belonging and employability, positioning the ideal worker as ethnically Swedish and marginalizing participants whose skills and experiences fall outside this norm. Within LLMP practices, employability is thus constructed through disciplinary processes that teach participants to embody 'Swedish' work ethics and behaviours, at the same time, as traditional gender roles are reinforced through gender-segregated tasks and training. The findings that activation programmes reinforce existing notions of ethnicity and gender align with previous studies (Johansson, Sarstrand Marekovic, and Forkby Söderqvist 2023; Nada 2023; Parsland and Ulmestig 2022; Söderqvist Forkby 2022; Vesterberg 2016). This study addresses a gap in the literature by demonstrating how participants navigate these normative structures.

Our contribution with this study is to show how migrant participants perceive themselves and their place in the labour market, as well as the meanings they attribute to work. We argue that participants are not passive recipients of these institutional expectations. They actively negotiate, adapt to, and resist the subject positions offered by LLMPs, revealing both the disciplining and enabling dimensions of LLMPs, as well as the complex ways in which work and identity are reconstructed within them. These findings thus highlight the broader implications of how activation programmes shape labour market integration and social belonging. LLMPs reproduce ethnic hierarchies and barriers, and gendered divisions of labour, influencing not only participants' current opportunities but also their perceived futures and aspirations.

Our study therefore contributes to a deeper understanding of how migrants and refugees experience, interpret, and navigate labour market programmes, emphasizing the need for policies that recognize prior skills, accommodate diverse capacities, and support more inclusive pathways towards employment and social integration.

Furthermore, previous studies on activation focus on either ethnicity or gender separately (Haikkola 2021; Johansson, Sarstrand Marekovic, and Forkby Söderqvist 2023; Parsland 2024; Söderqvist Forkby 2022; Vesterberg 2016). Our study fills a gap by examining the intertwinement of gender and ethnicity in activation. The meaning of work is both gendered and ethnicized for the participants: for many men, losing employment after migration signifies a loss of identity, status, and alignment with the ideal worker role. A lower status that the LLMP reinforces. In contrast, for some of the women, participation in labour market programmes offers a new, more independent subject position than in their home countries, allowing them to renegotiate gender expectations and challenge patriarchal norms. LLMPs thus position migrant women both as potentially liberated wage earners and as part of an exploited labour force in low-status jobs (cf. Nada 2023). This creates a duality in which labour market integration for migrant women involves both opportunity and vulnerability.

The tensions between gender norms and employment expectations underscore the dual nature of LLMPs: they both enable and constrain (Mulhall 2013). These programmes offer hope of labour market inclusion but also reproduce discourses of 'doing employment', positioning paid work as central. The programmes simultaneously offer a subject position as outside or excluded from (working) society and potential future inclusion through employment. The inclusions that LLMPs potentially offer are conditioned by ethnicized and gendered categorizations of the participants.

The barriers the participants in our study face in entering the labour market reflect an ethnicized version of Acker's (2012) concept of the abstract worker. Migrant participants are often positioned as distant from the ideal, employable worker-one who speaks fluent Swedish and has local education and work experience. By challenging the way we think about employability and who the ideal worker is, and can be, the results reveal the exclusionary logics that underpin activation policies and

labour market integration practices. These logics rest on culturally and morally charged ideals of productivity, language, and behaviour that obscure and devalue the skills, knowledge, and experiences migrants and refugees bring with them. In doing so, they reproduce conditions in which many remain positioned as perpetually 'becoming' employable; always in training but rarely recognized as fully qualified or belonging. Such processes not only restrict access to the labour market but also to full social membership and participation in society. Yet, by making these mechanisms visible, this study opens up the possibility of re-imagining work and inclusion beyond narrow notions of employability and adaptability, towards a more plural and inclusive understanding of what it means to work, to belong, and to take part in society.

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The study has obtained ethical approval from the Swedish Ethical Review Authority, registration number: 2022–02320-01.

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